

Mary Ierullo: a Willow Street angel

BY LAUREN GILLIESON

Another angel looks down on Willow Street today. Mary Ierullo, long-time resident of Willow Street in Ottawa's Little Italy, passed away on July 19 at the age of 85.

Ierullo, along with her daughter Angela, started the "Willow Street Angels" by getting the children involved in the community, in the planting of flowers and trees, and in cleaning up the Willow Street neighbourhood, where Ierullo lived.

"[Mary] loved kids and was great with children," St. Anthony School graduate Donny Dao explained at Ierullo's funeral Mass on July 22. "She would do activities with the children. She wanted children to go in her backyard to talk about things, to look at the garden, the flowers and the roses."

Ierullo and Angela had an activity for every season, said Dao, 13, who will attend Grade 8 at Notre Dame High School in the fall.

St. Anthony School principal John Dorner, and Dao's godfather, also spoke at Ierullo's memorial service. He, too, was extremely moved by Ierullo's interest and dedication to the neighbourhood's children. Dorner met Ierullo eight years ago, when he was assigned the position of principal at St. Anthony School — the school, incidentally, that Ierullo attended as a child. On the summer prior to starting his job at the school, Dorner contacted the West

Community Health Services Centre to introduce himself.

"I was told of a group of children in the community who were helping clean up the neighbourhood, students from St. Anthony and Cambridge schools," Dorner said. "I got a call from Angela Ierullo saying that she and her mother, Mary, would like me to join them and the Willow Street Angels at a barbecue in their backyard."

At the barbecue, Dorner said he found "many community leaders and countless children ... from a wide variety of cultural backgrounds, children of immigrants or immigrants themselves. Mary was sitting there like a queen enjoying every moment with children constantly approaching her. I met many of my students for the first time in Mary's backyard."

Mary Nazarena Dolores Parotta was born in Calabria, Italy in 1920 and moved to Canada with her widowed mother in 1929. They settled in Ottawa's Preston Street area a few years later. At the age of 31, Parotta married Vincenzo Ierullo and had three children, Peter, Anthony and Angela.

In 1952, Ierullo worked as a freelance court